BOOKS

Where the Wild Things Are

A new collection of essays reflects on the fascinating journey of nature and wildlife conservationists in India



AT THE FEET OF LIVING THINGS
Twenty-Five Years of Wildlife Research and Conservation in India
Eds. Aparajita Datta, Rohan Arthur and T.R. Shankar Raman
HARPERCOLLINS
₹599; 400 pages

The Nature Conservation Foundation (NCF) was set up a quarter century ago by a young, diverse group of scientists whose working lives began with degrees in wildlife biology, and who have learned much else along the way. This collection of essays by NCF members is a reflective, illuminating look at their journeys in Indian conservation. A John Steinbeck quote, which gives the book its title, reflects the authors' collective commitment to two ideas: first, that "the first rule of life is living", and second, that both the starfish and the student biologist who sits at the feet of living things know that they must "proliferate in all directions".

From green turtles in Lakshadweep to hornbills in Arunachal Pradesh, and from elephants in Tamil Nadu to snow leopards in Ladakh, this collection is permeated by the sense that the lives and destinies of human society and the wild are intertwined, and that both conservation and life are about more than the sum of their parts. It asks as many questions as it answers. Does one excise humans from the wild, or strive towards sustainable coexistence? How does one resolve conflicts that necessitate conservation, or are produced by it? How does one restore degraded habitats? How do you get people to fall in love with nature and help protect it?

These essays are by scientists, not novelists. Habitats, wildlife, problems and learnings are firmly foregrounded. There's more data here than lyricism—and that's as it should be. Yet, it's clear that the writers are driven by a deep love for and connection with the wild and its wonders. Their fascination and commitment shines through the pages in the massive investment of time and effort behind their recorded experiences—years spent in tough terrain and relative isolation, gruelling physical and emotional work, painstaking data-gathering, rigorous interrogation of their own assumptions, complicated interfaces with communities and apathetic governments. The moving passion is far from dry, so the driest of these pieces is readable. But there is also some very evocative writing—the standout essays for writerly flair are by Aparajita Datta on Namdapha and Pakke, Rohan Arthur on the resilience of a dying coral reef in Lakshadweep, and T.R. Shankar Raman and Divya Mudappa on the rainforests of Kalakad and the Anamalai hills.

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You will meet the wildlife and habitat—macaques, birds, dugongs, seagrass meadows and fragmented forests—but also the people who live alongside. Tribal groups in Arunachal Pradesh, the fisherfolk of the archipelagos, government officials, shopkeepers, school kids, birding enthusiasts, citizen scientists, people all over India.

The relationships between people and the wild, and between both of these and the scientist, are dauntingly complex. Yet, for all the enormity of the challenge, the takeaway from this collection is the remarkable steadfastness and resilience of those working to conserve India's natural world, finding hope in the successes and trying to learn from failure. Read it to wonder at our natural riches, to learn, and to feel humbled, grateful and inspired. ■

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